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California Establishes a Sister State Relationship with Syunik Province

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The California State Senate passed resolution ACR 105, a resolution to establish sister-state relationship between the State of California and the Province of Syunik. ACR 105 was first introduced by Assemblymember Chris Holden and was passed by the CA Assembly on September 2, 2021. The resolution is jointly authored by Assemblymember Adrin Nazarian and lists Assemblymembers Lisa Calderon, Vince Fong, Laura Friedman, Jesse Gabriel, Christina Garcia, Mike Gipson, Kevin Mullin, Luz M. Rivas, and Senators Bob Archuleta, Andreas Borgeas, Maria Elena Durazo, Robert Hertzberg, and Anthony Portantino as principal co-authors. Additionally, 62 CA legislators have been listed as co-authors.

The resolution declares California's solidarity with Syunik, the southernmost province in Armenia, and will facilitate mutually beneficial educational, economic, and cultural exchanges. Armenia and the United States are strategic partners, bound by historical kinship and shared values of democracy, freedom, and prosperity, and the passage of this resolution reaffirms this fact.

Syunik is one of the original provinces of the ancient Kingdom of Armenia and is currently bordered by Artsakh or Nagorno-Karabakh, Azerbaijan, and Iran. Syunik is home to the Armenian Stonehenge, Karahunj, that dates back to the bronze age; The Ughtasar Mountain petroglyphs that are 7,000 years old; the 9th Century Tatev Monastery that served as a center of scholastic and spiritual activity. The most populated town in the province is its capital, Kapan with 43,000 residents. In the aftermath of Azerbaijan's renewed war against the Armenians of Nagorno Karabakh Republic, the Azerbaijani military crossed into the Republic of Armenia and moved 3.5 kilometers into Syunik Province, seizing the entirety of Sev Lake. The next day, the Azerbaijani military breached two other sections of the border and occupied more areas of Armenia. Azerbaijan's illegal presence remains in Syunik, threatening Armenia's sovereignty and the people who live there.

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